

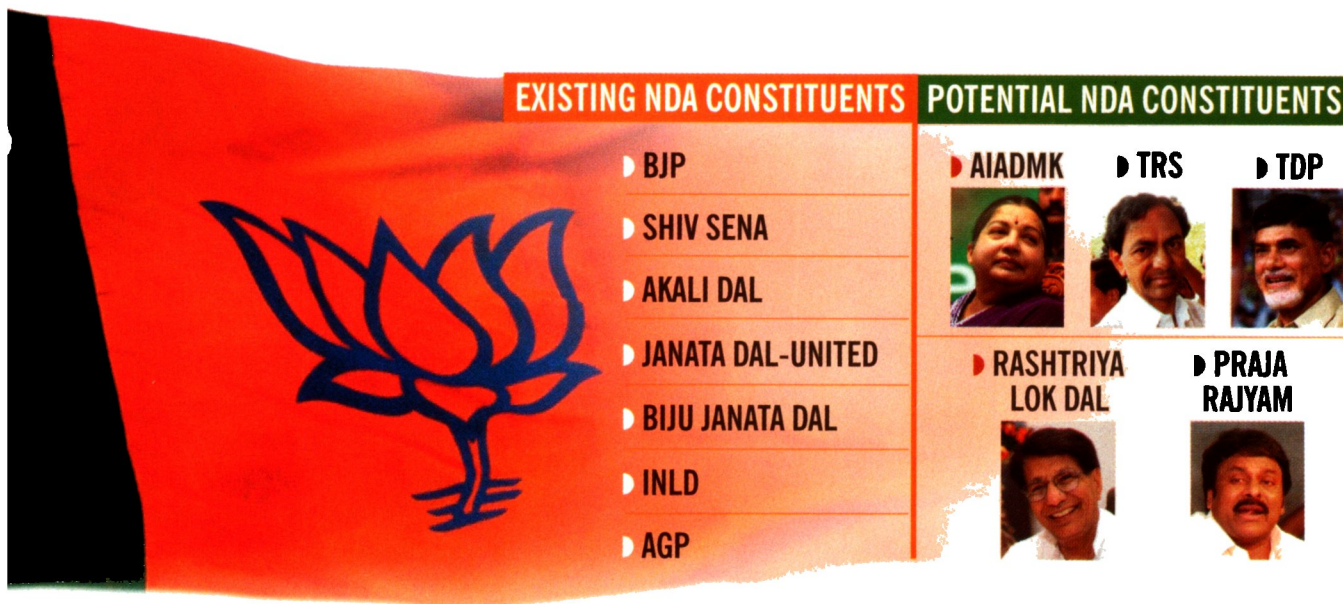
part of the NDA. The BJP is almost certain to get Ajit Singh's Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) on their side as well which would help them gain some ground in Uttar Pradesh. But before that they have to settle some internal differences with former Uttar Pradesh chief minister Kalyan Singh who is threatening to quit over the inclusion of Ajit Singh.

In most other northern states, the BJP expects a bipolar contest since the United National Progressive Alliance (UNPA)—an experiment with the Third Front—has more or less collapsed. For the party, the south holds the electoral key and in Andhra Pradesh, talks are on with various players

which the party had described as the "gateway to south", it is confident of managing on its own. The decision to hold the national executive meeting in Bangalore was driven primarily by the ambition to announce the party's arrival in the region.

In West Bengal, the obvious target is Trinamool Congress (TMC) but BJP leaders say that nothing could be said about her at this stage. "One can never be sure of Mamata. She may just come with the BJP post-poll. A pre-poll alliance will not suit her since it would go against the Muslim vote bank she is aiming at," a member of the BJP think-tank says.

Among the old NDA allies, the TMC and National



EXISTING NDA CONSTITUENTS	POTENTIAL NDA CONSTITUENTS
▶ BJP ▶ SHIV SENA ▶ AKALI DAL ▶ JANATA DAL-UNITED ▶ BIJU JANATA DAL ▶ INLD ▶ AGP	▶ AIADMK ▶ TRS ▶ TDP ▶ RASHTRIYA LOK DAL ▶ PRAJA RAJYAM

in the state. These include Telugu Desam Party (TDP), Telangana Rashtra Samiti (TRS) and Chiranjeevi's newly-formed Praja Rajyam Party. Andhra Pradesh is important for the BJP since it has never won any of the 42 Lok Sabha seats there.

In Tamil Nadu, the party is making serious efforts to get former chief minister J. Jayalalithaa's AIADMK on board. "In fact, she has sent feelers to our prime ministerial candidate, L.K. Advani. However, like another former ally, Mamata Banerjee, she is somewhat temperamental. In Tamil Nadu, we are most likely to get one of the big parties. If not AIADMK, then DMK will come. After all, it has been a part of the NDA in the past. It will all depend on the final results and the party's performance since most of these alliances would be post-poll," explains a party official. In fact, in the south, the BJP would prefer a post-poll alliance. For instance, a pre-poll alliance with Amma (Jayalalithaa) could prove counter-productive in other parts of the country, especially after the stance she adopted on the Kanchi Shankaracharya issue.

Regarding other southern states, the BJP does not have much at stake in Kerala. In Karnataka,

Conference (NC) continued to be intransigent. However, the BJP is not fretting much about the TMC, NC or other smaller parties. With most of their major original allies—Shiv Sena, Akali Dal, Janata Dal (United), Biju Janata Dal (BJD), AGP and INLD—with them, the party is only looking forward to increase its strength. BJP spokesperson Rajiv Pratap Rudy says that the NDA is carefully building up its new alliances while firmly holding on to most of the existing ones. "We hope to build certain strategic alliances as everyone understands the changing mood of the nation. The cobbled majority of the UPA is anyway facing political desertions with allies like the Left and the TRS leaving them," he adds.

The party president reflects the general optimism by saying that the NDA would definitely be as big as 1999 (when they won 298 Lok Sabha seats), if not bigger. With Congress allies like the Samajwadi Party (SP) and now the DMK taking on the Congress for the sake of preserving their own constituencies, the optimism over alliances may not be misplaced. And with the BSP deciding to expand its base in Delhi and other heartland states, BJP hopes it would further erode the Congress's votebank to its advantage.